

# The Simile of the Saw

## Kakacūpama Sutta (MN 21)

Ubhatodaṇḍakena cepi, bhikkhave, kakacena corā ocarakā aṅgamaṅgāni okanteyyuruṃ, tatrāpi yo mano padūseyya, na me so tena sāsanakaro. Tatrāpi vo, bhikkhave, evaṃ sikkhitabbaṃ: ‘na ceva no cittaṃ vipariṇataṃ bhavissati, na ca pāpikaṃ vācaṃ nicchāressāma, hitānukampī ca viharissāma mettacittā na dosantarā. Tañca puggalaṃ mettāsahagatena cetasā pharitvā viharissāma tadārammaṇaṃca sabbāvantarṃ lokaṃ mettāsahagatena cetasā vipulena mahaggatena appamāṇena averena abyābajjhena pharitvā viharissāmā’ti. Evañhi vo, bhikkhave, sikkhitabbaṃ.

"Monks, even if bandits were to cut you limb from limb with a two-handed saw, anyone who harbors a hateful mind in that moment is not following my teaching. Even then, monks, this is how you must train yourselves: 'Our minds will remain unaffected, and we will not utter any harsh words. We will dwell with compassion and goodwill, with a mind full of loving-kindness (*mettā*) and free of any hatred. We will radiate *mettā* to that person, and starting from them, we will fill the entire world with *mettā*—with a mind that is vast, exalted, boundless, free from enmity, and free from ill-will.' Indeed, monks, this is how you should train yourselves."

Imañca tumhe, bhikkhave, kakacūpamaṃ ovādaṃ abhikkhaṇaṃ manasi kareyyātha. Variant: Imañca → imañce (?) Passatha no tumhe, bhikkhave, taṃ vacanapathaṃ, aṇuruṃ vā thūlaṃ vā, yaṃ tumhe nādhivāseyyāthā’ti?

"Monks, you should constantly reflect on this advice of the simile of the saw (*kakacūpama*). Do you see any kind of speech, subtle or coarse, that you would not be able to endure?"

"No hetam, bhante".

"No, Venerable Sir."

"Tasmātiha, bhikkhave, imaṃ kakacūpamaṃ ovādaṃ abhikkhaṇaṃ manasikarotha. Taṃ vo bhavissati dīgharattaṃ hitāya sukhāyā’ti.

"Therefore, monks, keep this advice of the *kakacūpama* constantly in mind. That will bring you long-lasting welfare and happiness (*sukha*)."

Idamavoca bhagavā. Attamanā te bhikkhū bhagavato bhāsitaṃ abhinandunti.

This is what the Blessed One said. The monks were delighted and rejoiced in the Blessed One's words.

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## Glossary

| Pāli (IAST)       | Target transliteration | Target gloss                                                    | First-chapter occurrence | Goenka-tradition usage                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>bhikkhu</b>    | bhikkhu                | monk; meditator                                                 | The Simile of the Saw    | In Goenkaji's discourses, <i>bhikkhu</i> is frequently understood as any meditator walking the path of Dhamma, not just an ordained monk. |
| <b>citta</b>      | citta                  | mind;<br>consciousness                                          | The Simile of the Saw    | The mind/consciousness that Vipassana meditators observe, train, and purify.                                                              |
| <b>mettā</b>      | mettā                  | loving-kindness;<br>benevolence;<br>goodwill towards all beings | The Simile of the Saw    | The active cultivation of selfless love and compassion cultivated and shared with all beings at the end of a Vipassana session.           |
| <b>kakacūpama</b> | kakacūpama             | simile of the saw                                               | The Simile of the Saw    | The title of this discourse, illustrating the                                                                                             |

| Pāli (IAST)  | Target transliteration | Target gloss          | First-chapter occurrence | Goenka-tradition usage                                                                |
|--------------|------------------------|-----------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|              |                        |                       |                          | ultimate standard of non-anger, patience, and compassion.                             |
| <b>sukha</b> | sukha                  | happiness; well-being | The Simile of the Saw    | Experiential happiness that naturally arises as a consequence of mental purification. |

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## Translator Notes

1. **Intimate and Direct Register:** Kept the language simple, direct, and conversational to preserve the warm "teacher-to-student" voice of Goenkaji's discourse style rather than standard scholarly/academic translation prose.
2. **First-Occurrence Pāli Integration:** Incorporated the Pāli terms *mettā*, *kakacūpama*, and *sukha* inline with their respective glosses on their first occurrence, ensuring that the Pāli vocabulary remains present and clear for the practitioner's understanding.
3. **Lineage Terminology:** Used standard lineage-faithful English terms (e.g., "loving-kindness", "goodwill", "Venerable Sir", "welfare and happiness") matching the terminology found in Goenka-tradition publications.